

Clocking Out

Written by

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INT. FACTORY FLOOR - EVENING

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The machinery CHURNS and CLANKS in a deafening rhythm. MIKE, a simple factory worker wearing an orange vest and earmuffs stands in front of a conveyor belt, moving an overhead funnel to align with the containers on the belt below, filling them with a white powder. Mike looks tired.

After filling several containers, Mikes attention is piqued by a conversation being had by the door which he can just make out

JERRY

C'mon guys this is ridiculous!-

Jerry, one of Mikes co workers is being forcefully escorted out of the building by 2 heavily armored security guards holding a cardboard box.

GUARD #1

Chapter 18, section 3 of the contract. You missed too much work and are charged with desertion.

JERRY

Desertion? Im a factory worker, not a damn soldier. All I do is place the labels on the boxes!

Jerry wrestles himself free from the guards and turns around to face them

JERRY (CONT'D)

I already told Mr.Sterling, I had to miss 3 days. My father died, I had to be with my brothers. Guys, come on, you understand right?

The 2nd guard, completely ignoring him turns Jerry around and continues pushing him out the door

GUARD # 2

You have been terminated from your position at MegaCorp and are no longer allowed on the premises.

JERRY (CONT'D)

Wait, please don't do this, I have people relying on me-

Before being shoved out the door, Jerry glances at Mike who's been staring this entire time. Mike slowly turns away, and looks down at his containers, continuing to fill.

The rest of the factory floor quickly settles back into its monotonous routine after the show.

A middle aged man in a track suit jogs down the line of the factory observing all the workers, and stopping at Mike.

MR. STERLING

Make sure you're filling those all the way kid. And were going to need an extra batch since we were short yesterday. Thanks champ

Before Mike gets the chance to reply, he continues jogging down the line.

MIKE

Yes sir.

EXT. COMPANY PARKING LOT - NIGHT

Mike exits the building, bags under his eyes, fluorescent lights buzz over head. Half the lot is empty.

He walks toward the street.

EXT. SIDEWALK - CONTINUOUS

A homeless encampment lines the block. One of the tents is selling trinkets laid out on a blanket. Mike is seen handing the lady running it some cash and takes a collar with a bow. Mike makes his way to the subway entrance.

INT. SUBWAY CAR - CONTINUOUS

Mike is standing in an overcrowded train, shoulder to shoulder with the other riders as they shift back and forth to the motion of the dimly lit cab.

INT. APARTMENT BUILDING - CONTINUOUS

Mike walks up to the door of his apartment. As he's messing with his keys, the door of the apartment next to his opens and an OLDER WOMAN steps out.

MARIANNE

Its nearly 11. This is what, 3 weeks straight of them working you to death?

Mike gives her a quick glance and smiles through his exhausted demeanor.

MIKE

It's alright, you know I could use the hours. Besides, you know what were making, that equipment can save lives. I don't mind staying later for that

(beat)

How's Lucy been?

MARIANNE

(sighing)

Lucy is ok. lazy as ever. She just lays about all day y'know, I need to find someone willing to take her on walks, she's getting fat!

MIKE

(smiling)

We'll take her to work, she can walk on the conveyor belt!

MARIANNE

(laughing)

Oh, she'd love that. Until she gets stuck in a box and gets sent to Canada or wherever these things go.

(beat)

But I really am worried about you, this is unhealthy.

MIKE

I know, If they ask again tomorrow I promise I'll tell them no, ok?

Marianne looks down and sighs, then nods silently.

LUCY, an orange house cat appears next to Marianne in the door frame

LUCY

Meow

MIKE

Hey there you are! Look what I got you-

Mike kneels down in front of the cat and pulls the bow collar he bought earlier out of his pocket and places it around her neck. Lucy begins purring and rolling on the floor as Mike stands back up.

MARIANNE  
 (placing a hand over her  
 heart)  
 Thank you mike, she looks adorable.

MIKE  
 Hopefully she likes it! Theres a  
 space for you to write her name  
 just in case she gets lost.  
 (beat)  
 I should head to sleep, got work in  
 the morning. Goodnight Marianne,  
 goodnight Lucy!

LUCY  
 Purr

Marianne picks up the cat and heads inside while mike does  
 the same.

INT. FACTORY FLOOR - MORNING

Mike walks into work and notices a crowd has gathered around  
 one of the stations.

Walking over, he notices the plaque saying "Jerry" is being  
 removed, and an automatic labeler is being installed.

As the machine whirrs to life, it successfully labels several  
 boxes. The crowd murmurs

JEREMIAH  
 They replaced him with a machine!

Jeremiah, a large man who's carrying a crate speaks up from  
 the crowd and draws their attention. He places the crate down  
 and stands on it to gain height

JEREMIAH (CONT'D)  
 Our friend lost his lively hood  
 yesterday, and so did many others  
 before him. Are you all not tired  
 of how they treat us? Like we're  
 disposable?

The crowd nods in agreement.

JEREMIAH (CONT'D)  
 The truth is, we don't need them,  
 they need US! How much longer until  
 every one of us is replaced? I say  
 enough is enough. We will show them  
 that without us, they have NOTHING!

The group applauds and cheers, inspired by the speech and begin discussing,...

WORKER 1  
Are we going on strike?

WORKER 2  
How does this work?

After some deliberation, Mr. Sterling power walks into the factory floor with 2 heavily armed guards behind him.

MR. STERLING  
What is all this? All of you, back  
to work. NOW!

The crowd slowly disperses as Mr. Sterling and his guards monitor the floor. The crowd moves on, and they whisper to each other. Jeremiah picks his crate back up and walks toward the warehouse, stopping by Mike on the way

JEREMIAH  
(whispering)  
Tomorrow, we're all going on  
strike. You in?

MIKE  
(whispering)  
Yea, of course I'm in. You all can  
count on me!

Jeremiah smiles and gives Mike a hearty slap on the back, then continues on. Mike hobbles over to his station and gets back to work.

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INT. APARTMENT - NIGHT

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A silent apartment is disturbed by the FLIPPING of a mechanical clock on a table that reads 12:05. Just then, the door opens and Mike walks inside looking dead tired. He waddles over to the couch and yawns before collapsing onto it, passing out almost immediately.

INT. APARTMENT - DAY

A silent apartment is disturbed by Mike falling off the couch and making a THUD on the floor. The mechanical clock FLIPS to 9:20 as Mike groans, picking himself up slowly, stretching as he goes. With one eye open, Mike walks passed the table and makes it halfway down the hall before stopping, turning slowly and walking carefully back toward the clock. He picks it up and looks at the time.

MIKE  
Oh crap-

Mike drops the clock and quickly gathers all of his things, rushing out the door as fast as he can.

EXT. COMPANY PARKING LOT - DAY

A picket line of strikers lines the parking lot behind a makeshift fence in front of the factory. CHANTING and ARGUING can be heard between the workers and the guards lined up by the main entrance. Mike is barely able to keep his eyes open and is continuously yawning while he walks passed the strikers into the factory, wearing his earmuffs.

INT. FACTORY FLOOR - DAY

Mike makes it to his station and still sleep deprived, flicks all the switches and buttons to get his equipment turned on.

Mike gets his vest on and stands in position when he sees that the station in front of him is empty. He looks confused and turns his head to look at the next one, which is also empty. He walks into the middle of the aisle and looks down the length of the line, which is completely deserted.

MIKE

What?

Some footsteps can be heard coming from the entrance and Mike turns to see Mr. Sterling with his guards, and EVELINE, a woman in a fancy dress and a hard hat.

MR. STERLING

There he is, my boy Nick!

MIKE

Its actually Mike

MR. STERLING

That's what I said. Listen, I always knew you were my favorite! Of course you would know better than to participate in some 'Strike', those ingrates.

Mikes eyes go wide with realization, before hesitating to answer his boss

MIKE

Yeah, of course, you're right-

MR. STERLING

Of course I'm right. and hey kid

Mr.Sterling gestures toward Eveline.

MR.STERLING (CONT'D)  
This is the CEO of MegaCorp. She  
wants to talk!

EVELINE  
It's a pleasure to meet you,.. Mike  
was it?

She extends her arm for a handshake. Mike, who is taken aback  
reciprocates and locks his hand with hers.

MIKE  
That's right Ma'am, I work in  
station 32D, just over there,

He gestures toward the empty station behind them. Eveline  
doesn't even look.

EVELINE  
How would you like a promotion?  
"Head of the factory floor"!

MIKE  
That would be great-

EVELINE  
(interrupting)  
Yes very great, It's a role  
perfectly suited for you. All you  
have to do is,

She gestures towards the main entrance. Mike takes a step and  
looks out the window, seeing all his co-workers outside

EVELINE (CONT'D)  
Convince them to come back to work.  
Be an example to these lost sheep.

EXT. COMPANY PARKING LOT - MINUTES LATER

Mike steps out into the parking lot with a megaphone and a  
badge that reads Head of the factory floor. It quiets down as  
everyone turns to face him

MIKE  
(through megaphone)  
Uhh hey everyone-

The megaphone is louder than expected, everyone winces. Mike  
puts it away

MIKE (CONT'D)  
Hey everyone, hows it going?

A couple people yell from the crowd

STRIKER #1  
What are you doing man?

STRIKER #2  
Traitor!

MIKE  
Have you guys met Eveline? She's  
really nice, and uh wants you all  
to come back to work,.

The yelling gets more intense, and they start BOOING him, one worker throws his sandwich at him. Mike gets hit by his lunch and is wiping away the condiments from his face

MIKE (CONT'D)  
Cmon guys, thats a waste of food!

STRIKER #1  
And you're a waste of space!

The crowd gets more rowdy as Mike is escorted back inside by Evelin's guards. He looks back, and locks eyes with Marianne, who's near the front of picket line, looking concerned. Mike looks away and heads back inside.

INT. TOP FLOOR HALL - DUSK

Mike sits near a window in the hall, looking down at the strikers who are still going as he writes ideas into a notebook on how to end the strike. He glances at a clock on the wall, its getting late.

MIKE  
This will have to do,.

He gets up and walks to the big board room doors about to enter, when he heres YELLING coming from the other side of the door. Mike puts his ear up to it and listens in,.

INT. TOP FLOOR OFFICE - CONTINUOUS

Eveline, Sterling and a few other suits are huddled around a large desk

MR. STERLING

(yelling)

This is bad! We lost an entire days  
production, were already cutting it  
close as is-

A CRACK OF THUNDER interrupts the makeshift conference, as it  
starts raining outside

EVELINE

Oh good, that should weed at least  
some of them out. And calm down  
sterling, theres no need for that.  
but we do need them back in here  
now.

EXECUTIVE #1

We could lie? Give in to their  
demands, but back track later. We  
can't afford to have these reports  
leaking before we get all the  
product out the door.

EVELINE

Normally I'd agree, but were months  
away from breaking even, and we  
cant afford another strike in that  
time. We can't afford to just wait  
them out either,

The room goes quiet as everyone thinks of a solution. Eveline  
gets angrier and angrier

EVELINE (CONT'D)

These miserable rats. Thinking they  
know anything about the real world.  
They know nothing. Not even that if  
they delay any longer, none of them  
will have a job anymore. We might  
have to just do this the old  
fashioned way. GUARDS!

A few heavily armed guards begin following her out the door.  
Mike chases after them

MIKE

Hey! Whats going on? You appointed  
me negotiator, I should be involved

He follows them into the freight elevator

EVELINE

Force, mr Mike. We will keep them  
in line with force. Sad that they  
put me in this position

Mikes eyes go wide with shock

MIKE

What? You can't do that, those are  
my friends!

EVELINE

Oh hush now. If everyone complies,  
no one will be seriously hurt. Its  
going to be your job to convince  
them to come back in. If anyone  
gets injured, its on you. So, do  
your best to get them back in here

The elevator reaches the ground floor and the small army  
march toward the entrance, Mike walks with them as his mind  
races

EXT. COMPANY PARKING LOT - EVENING

The guards surround the strikers. Eveline speaks to them  
through a megaphone

EVELINE

You will ALL return to work.  
Anyone who doesn't voluntarily,  
will be made to.

She nods at the guards as they prepare their night sticks at  
the crowd. The crowd looks weary. After some time, a few  
start to walk towards the entrance, when a voice calls out

MARIANNE

Wait! Everyone!

Marianne walks to the front of the line and addresses the  
crowd

MARIANNE (CONT'D)

We cant let them bully us into  
submission. They HAVE to listen to  
us, we just need to hold out a bit  
longer! This egregious display only  
shows how desperate they've become

EVELINE

Shut up! Why is it so hard to just  
do what your told?

Eveline points to a guard and gestures him toward Marianne. He approaches her and raises his arm above her head, but Marianne just stares at Eveline and doesn't move. The crowd is still and Eveline is shaking with anger

EVELINE (CONT'D)  
(yelling)  
Get rid of her!

She gestures to the guard to swing. he gets in position, but out of nowhere Mike jumps in front of the baton.

MIKE  
Hold on! Wow, wait!

He holds his hands up and faces Eveline

MIKE (CONT'D)  
I won't let you hurt my friend.

Mike turns to face the crowd.

MIKE (CONT'D)  
Everyone, Marianne is right. We need to stand up for ourselves, I'm sorry I didn't see that sooner. look around! There are more of us than there are of them, and they NEED us. I know what they're doing here, she can't afford to hurt any of you.

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EXT. COMPANY PARKING LOT - EVENING

Mike turns to face Eveline and points at her.

MIKE  
(shouting)  
Everyone! She's been using us. All of us. She doesn't care about this place, and she doesn't care about any of you. Why do you think she's here herself? Why bring guards? Why bring weapons?  
Because they're scared.  
They need us more than we need them.

The crowd starts to shift. Workers look at each other. The fear begins turning into anger.

MIKE (CONT'D)

I heard them talking upstairs,  
They're desperate and behind  
schedule. They can't finish without  
us.

(beat)

This whole place stops without us.

Eveline steps forward, furious.

EVELINE

That's enough! Arrest him!

The guards hesitate.

MIKE

Look around! There's more of us  
than there are of them. If we give  
in now, nothing changes.  
Tomorrow it'll be someone else.  
Then someone else.  
Jerry. Marianne. Me. You.

Marianne steps up beside him.

MARIANNE

He's right.

a few more workers join them physically. Now it becomes a  
wall of people.

EVELINE

Guards! Listen to me!

but this time they don't move.

MR. STERLING

Ma'am... maybe we should reconsider

—

EVELINE

No. I will not be spoken to this  
way by animals!

She turns toward the group, and speaks to Mike.

EVELINE (CONT'D)

Stop this! Just do what you're  
told!

Mike pauses a beat, and tears off the "head of the factory  
floor" badge he was given, before dropping it on the ground.

MIKE  
Im done blindly following orders.  
Why don't you tell everyone what it  
is we're doing here.

The crowd murmurs, looking around at each other in confusion.

STRIKER #1  
We make medical supplies,

STRIKER #2  
We help people!

EVELINE  
Thats not their concern!

MIKE  
No. It is.  
There's a defect in those machines.  
And you knew it.  
You had us push them out anyway.

STRIKER #1  
The reports... they told us to ignore  
them..

The crowd shifts, this time not just angry but disturbed.

MIKE  
We didn't know. But they did.

All eyes on Eveline.

MIKE (CONT'D)  
(quietly)  
We thought we were helping.

Silence.

EVELINE  
People needed those machines,  
Delays cost lives too!

She looks around the crowd frantically.

EVELINE (CONT'D)  
Enough! Guards, put an end to this  
already!

The guards hold for a moment, still facing the workers,  
before one lowers his baton. The others, one by one follow  
and lower all their weapons. The crowd turns to stare at the  
CEO.

Beat

Eveline lets out a frustrated grunt as she tries to run, but is captured by her own security after only a few feet.

EVELINE (CONT'D)  
Let go of me!

GUARD #1  
(quiet, conflicted)  
.....Sorry ma'am, I can't do that.

In the chaos, Mr. Sterling tries to sneak away as well but is intercepted by Jeremiah and a few of the other strikers.

JEREMIAH  
Going somewhere?

EXT. COMPANY PARKING LOT - LATER

Eveline and Mr. Sterling are put away in police cruisers and officers are talking to the different strikers. Mike and a detective finish conversing and he walks away.

STRIKER #2  
Hey, great job man!

Mike just nods as a few strikers pass him, one giving him a pat on the back. Marianne walks up.

MARIANNE  
They cleared me to go home. How about you?

MIKE  
I'm also good to go.

Light fills the area as the sun peaks over the horizon. Its now dawn.

MARIANNE  
All night at the factory? That might be a new record!

MIKE  
For you maybe, I'm used to sunrises around here.

The two chuckle.

MIKE (CONT'D)  
Cmon, lets go home. I owe Lucy a couple head pats.

Marianne and mike walk off the lot and down the street,  
talking the whole way.